

College of Future Technology Red Bird MPhil Program Graduation Procedure Guideline

Only Applicable to RBM Students

Updated in November, 2025

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Preface:

This Guideline is designed to serve as a reference manual for RBM students, offering a structured framework to navigate the detailed procedures involved in Thesis Examination and Graduation.

The Guideline outlined in this document are based on the policies of *[Handbook for Research Postgraduate Studies HKUST\(GZ\)](#)* and the policies of College of Future Technology. In case of any discrepancy, the university level policies shall prevail.

All students are encouraged to familiarize themselves with this guideline to ensure a smooth and successful transition through the graduation process.

Base of Red Bird MPhil

College of Future Technology, VPTLO

HKUST(GZ)

November 2025

1. Graduation Guidelines Released by the University

During the preparation for graduation and the MPhil Thesis Examination, it is essential for each student to thoroughly read the terms and guidelines related to "Curriculum Requirements - Thesis Research," as detailed in the following sections of the [*Handbook for Research Postgraduate Studies HKUST\(GZ\)*](#):

- [Guidelines on Thesis Preparation](#)
- [Guidelines on MPhil Thesis Examination Committees](#)
- [Guidelines for Scheduling, Preparing for and Executing MPhil Thesis Examinations](#)
- [Guidelines on Conducting MPhil and PhD Thesis Examinations](#)
- [Guidelines on Hybrid Thesis Examination Arrangement](#)
- [HKUST\(GZ\) PG Graduation Guide](#) (released by the ARS)

*If the links to the Guidelines above are not accessible, please enter the "Curriculum Requirements" section in the [*Handbook for Research Postgraduate Studies HKUST\(GZ\)*](#), then navigate to the "Thesis Research" section, and click on each guideline to view them individually.*

2. Degree Conferral Date

There are five annual dates for degree conferral listed below:

- (1) 31 January
- (2) 31 March
- (3) 31 May
- (4) 31 July*

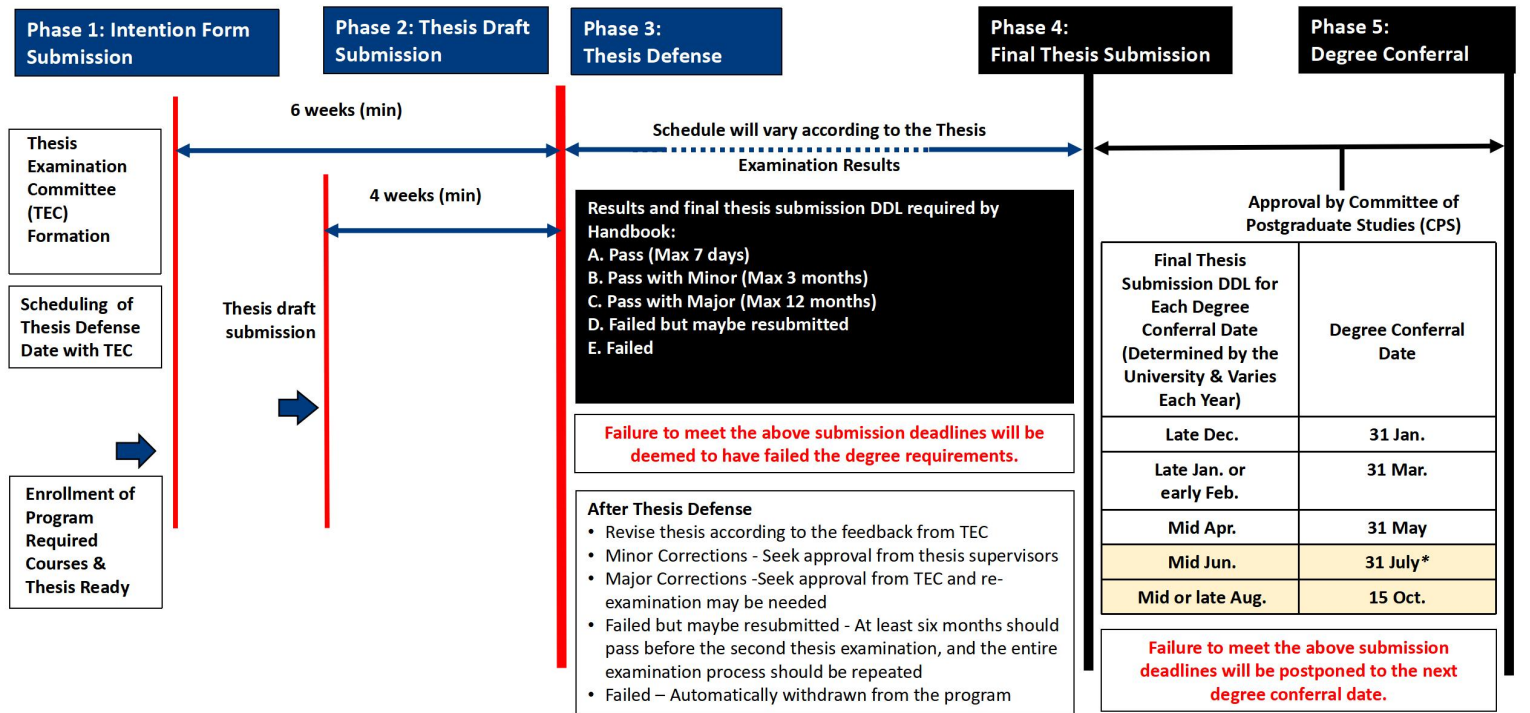
** Subject to the approval by the University Council, the degree conferral date in July may be changed to July 15 starting from 2025/26 academic year.*

- (5) 15 October

Students will automatically have their degrees conferred at the immediate next session of the degree conferral that follows the HKUST Committee on Postgraduate Studies (CPS) meeting in which their graduation is confirmed (e.g. students who receive HKUST CPS approval to graduate in January will have their degrees conferred on 31st January). **An electronic copy of the diploma, Award Certification Letter (ACL) and academic transcript will be issued after the degree is conferred. The degree diploma and a free copy of the academic transcript will be ready for collection on a later date.**

3. Phases and Milestones for Graduation

For the phases and milestones related to graduation, please refer to the figure below:



* Subject to the approval by the University Council, the degree conferral date in July may be changed to July 15 starting from 2025/26 academic year.

Figure: Phases and Milestones for Graduation

4. Suggested Timeline for Thesis Examination

Preparation

Thesis Examination Intention Submission DDL <i>(The intention must be submitted no less than 6 weeks before the proposed thesis examination date)</i>	Thesis Draft Submission DDL <i>(The thesis draft approved by Thesis Supervisors and ready for examination purpose must be submitted no less than 4 weeks before the proposed thesis examination date)</i>	Suggested MPhil Thesis Examination DDL* <i>(Based on the thesis examination result - "Passed subject to minor corrections"- which requires approximately 3 weeks to revise the thesis and obtain approval)</i>	Submission DDL of Revised Thesis (Approved by Thesis Supervisors/TEC) & Signature Page (Signed by Thesis Supervisors) to RBM-At least 5 working days before the <u>final thesis submission deadline*</u>	Submission DDL for <u>Final Thesis*</u> to the University's Thesis Submission System for Each Degree Conferral (Decided by the university)	Degree Conferral Date
12 October 2025	26 October 2025	23 November 2025	14 December 2025	21 December 2025	31 January 2026
13 November 2025	27 November 2025	25 December 2025	15 January 2026	22 January 2026	31 March 2026
Around 8 February 2026	Around 22 February 2026	Around 22 March 2026	Around 12 April 2026	Mid April 2026 (TBD)	31 May 2026
Around 5 April 2026	Around 19 April 2026	Around 17 May 2026	Around 7 June 2026	Mid June 2026 (TBD)	31 July 2026 (Subject to change)
Around 14 June 2026	Around 28 June 2026	Around 26 July 2026	Around 16 August 2026	Mid or late August 2026 (TBD)	15 October 2026

Figure: Suggested Timeline for Thesis Examination Preparation

Note: The timeline outlined above is based on a defense result of "Passed subject to minor corrections," which needs at least about 3 weeks to complete the necessary revisions and the subsequent approval and signing process. If the result is "Passed subject to major corrections," significantly more time will be required for thesis revision and obtaining the necessary approvals.

*Suggested MPhil Thesis Examination DDL

1. These deadlines are not fixed and may allow for some flexibility. However, the later the defense is completed, the tighter the timeframe for revisions and signatures, which could jeopardize meeting the current degree conferral date.
2. Thesis Examination Intention Submission DDL and Thesis Draft Submission DDL are determined by counting backward from the Thesis Examination Date.

*Final Thesis Submission Deadline:

1. Final thesis submission deadlines required by the Handbook based on students' exam results *(Missing this deadline will be deemed to have failed the degree requirements)*:

- A. Passed: **within one week** of the date of the thesis examination.
 - B. Passed subjected to minor corrections: **within 3 months** from the date of the thesis examination, **or a date specified by the TEC, whichever is earlier.**
 - C. Passed subjected to major corrections: **within 12 months** from the date of the thesis examination, **or a date specified by the TEC, whichever is earlier.**
 - D. Failed but maybe resubmitted: the entire examination process be repeated, at least six months should pass before the second examination.
 - E. Failed
2. Final thesis submission deadlines required by the university for each degree conferral date (as indicated in the blue column of the figure “Suggested Timeline for Thesis Examination Preparation) (**Missing this deadline will be postponed to the next degree conferral date**).

Therefore, for the final thesis submission deadline, students should adhere to the earlier of the two deadlines: either the one stipulated by the thesis exam results or the one corresponding to the student’s desired degree conferral date, as outlined in points 1 and 2.

***Final Thesis refers to the Revised Thesis**

- 1. Approved by the prime supervisor and co-supervisor (if “Passed” or “Passed subjected to minor corrections”) or approved by the TEC members (if “Passed subjected to major corrections”)
- 2. Signature page of the final thesis has been signed by the prime supervisor, co-supervisor, and thrust head.

5. Thesis Examination Procedures for RBM Students

Step 1: Ensure all program required courses enrolled and thesis ready

- Students check whether they meet the [2024-25 program curriculum requirements](#) through the SIS system:

[SIS--Student Center--Academic Requirements](#) (select from the dropdown list and click ">>") 

- Students communicate with their Thesis Supervisors (Prime Supervisor and Co-supervisor) regarding whether their thesis meets the graduation requirements before submitting the Thesis Examination Intention.
- Reference:

[Guidelines on Thesis Preparation](#)

[MPhil Thesis Template](#)

Step 2: Formation of Thesis Examination Committee (TEC) and Submission of Thesis Examination Intention

- Students communicate with their Thesis Supervisors to request recommendations for the members of the Thesis Examination Committee (TEC), and confirm the thesis examination date, as well as the attendance mode of each TEC member (in-person or online) with all TEC members. Please be reminded that the candidate and at least two additional participants (either the Chairperson or a TEC member) must attend in person; otherwise, the thesis examination cannot proceed. **If students submit the intention form without prior communication and confirmation, the thesis examination cannot proceed as scheduled, which may potentially affect graduation time.**
- An MPhil TEC shall consist of at least **four** faculty members, including:
 - **A Chairperson (HKUST(GZ) internal faculty);**
 - **Prime supervisor and Co-supervisor;**
 - **One other HKUST(GZ) internal faculty member.**

CFT Project Supervisors are eligible to serve on the Thesis Examination Committee (TEC) for MPhil students. And the TEC must include at least three academic members at the rank of Assistant Professor or above.

- Students submit the “Thesis Examination Intention” through the Thesis Examination System (<https://thesisexam.hkust-gz.edu.cn>). The user guide is available for all users on the system homepage. The intention must be submitted no less than six weeks before the proposed thesis examination date and the Thesis Examination System is set accordingly.

The intention needs to be approved by: Prime Supervisor, Co-Supervisor, Thrust PG Coordinator, and Thrust Head. After submitting the intention, please remind the Prime Supervisor and Co-Supervisor to review and approve it in a timely manner.

Once the intention has been approved, the Thesis Examination Committee members, Thesis Examination Date and attendance mode of each TEC member cannot be changed without solid justifications.

- Reference:

[Guidelines on MPhil Thesis Examination Committees](#)

[Guidelines for Scheduling, Preparing for and Executing MPhil Thesis Examinations](#)

[Guidelines on Hybrid Thesis Examination Arrangement](#)

Step 3: Draft Thesis Submission

- **Thesis Originality check via iThenticate:** Please refer to the “iThenticate User Guides” (<https://hkust-gz.libguides.com/iThenticateGuides>) for Originality check. Thesis Supervisors should advise students on whether it is appropriate to exclude bibliography and works cited including students’ own previously published papers from the checking as well as the requirements for similarity rate.
- Please remember to check in advance whether the iThenticate account is activated. Avoid waiting until the day of the thesis draft submission to use the account for the first time. Additionally, if the iThenticate account has not been used for an extended period, it may be automatically deactivated. If students encounter any issues regarding the iThenticate account, please contact the Library at library@hkust-gz.edu.cn and evayhzeng@hkust-gz.edu.cn for assistance.
- **Students submit the draft thesis and iThenticate report (similarity report) approved by Thesis Supervisors to the Thesis Examination System** (<https://thesisexam.hkust-gz.edu.cn>). Please make sure the thesis and similarity report are named according to the format below:

-Thesis: 1st Version Thesis_Name(e.g. Shan ZHANG)_Student ID

-Similarity Report: Similarity Report_Name (e.g. Shan ZHANG)_Student ID

Note: When a student’s intention is approved, the system will automatically send an email notification that includes a link for submitting the draft thesis and the

iThenticate report. The draft thesis must be submitted no less than four weeks before the proposed thesis examination date. Even if the intention has not yet been approved and the system does not send the email notification, students are still required to submit their thesis draft to the Thesis Examination System by this deadline. Failing to do so, students may be required to postpone the Thesis Examination.

Step 4: Thesis Examination Preparation and Completion

- Students prepare the presentation for the Thesis Examination. It is advisable to start with a brief introduction to the group project and explain the connection between their individual project and the group project.
- Students confirm with their Thesis Supervisors whether they need to print a physical copy of their thesis and inquire about any specific printing requirements.
- **Three working days before the defense**, students should remind all Thesis Examination Committee (TEC) members of the time and venue of the defense and reconfirm the attendance mode for all TEC members. *If a TEC member's attendance mode differs from what was submitted in the Thesis Examination Intention Form, students should email the RBM at least two working days in advance, providing an explanation for the change in attendance mode.* However, it is essential to ensure that the candidate and at least two additional participants (either the Chairperson or a TEC member) can participate in person.
- According to the university's policy, if there is a conflict between thesis examinations and business travel commitments, faculty members should prioritize thesis examinations. For hybrid mode thesis examinations, RBM will assist in setting up the Zoom meeting and will send the link to the faculty members the day before the examination.
- **On the day of the Thesis Examination**, students should arrive at the venue 20 minutes early to set up the computer and presentation. If there are no faculty members attending online, it is advisable for students to use a USB drive to transfer their presentation to the classroom computer. If faculty members are joining remotely, students should use their personal computer to log into the Zoom meeting set up by RBM and share their screen.
- *Please refer to the “Guidelines on Conducting MPhil and PhD Thesis Examinations” for detailed procedures regarding the defense, examination results, and the corresponding deadlines for submitting the final version of the thesis.*
- Reference:

[Guidelines on Hybrid Thesis Examination Arrangement](#)

[Guidelines on Conducting MPhil and PhD Thesis Examinations](#)

Step 5: Thesis Revision, Approval, and Signature Procedure

- Students revise the thesis according to the feedback provided by the TEC members.
- Students get approval for the revised thesis:
 - **Passed:** Students submit the final thesis to Thesis Supervisors and ask them to sign on the Signature Page.
 - **Passed subject to minor corrections:** Students submit the revised thesis and similarity report to Thesis Supervisors for review and ask them to sign on the Signature Page.
 - **Passed subject to major corrections:** Students submit the revised thesis and similarity report to all TEC members for review via email and cc RBM. Once all panel members approve the revised thesis, students ask Thesis Supervisors to sign on the Signature Page. For students who are required to undergo a second defense, after completing the necessary revisions, they will need to schedule a new time for the second defense with the TEC members.
- **Once the Thesis Supervisors have provided their signatures, students are required to submit the**
 - (1) **signed Signature Page** (the Signature Page must strictly adhere to the formatting of the attached “SAMPLE SIGNATURE PAGE”-Annex I).
 - (2) **final thesis** (the final version of the thesis must strictly adhere to [the formatting requirements outlined in the Handbook](#)).
 - (3) **and similarity report** (only required when the result is “Passed subject to minor/major corrections”)

to RBM via the link below: <https://forms.office.com/r/0aDUpW1ks5>.
- RBM will assist in obtaining the thrust head's signature on the Signature Page and then send the signed page back to students.

Step 6: Final Thesis Submission

- **Upon receiving the duly signed Signature Page, students upload and submit the Signature Page and the Authorization Page as a PDF file and the final thesis as another PDF file to the University's Thesis Submission System (<https://hkust-gz.libguides.com/thesis>). The students do not need to replace the two unsigned pages in the thesis PDF with the scanned signature pages.**
- **Final Thesis Submission DDL:**

Please make sure to submit the final thesis to the University's Thesis Submission

System by the deadline specified in the Handbook or within the time frame required by the TEC.

- **Passed:** the candidate must, **within one week** of the date of the thesis examination, submit an electronic copy of the final thesis, together with the electronic copy of the authorization page containing the student's signature, and a signature page containing signatures of the thesis supervisor(s) and Thrust/ Division Head, to the University's Thesis Submission System.

- **Passed subject to minor corrections:** the final thesis and the iThenticate report must be submitted **within 3 months** from the date of the thesis examination, **or a date specified by the TEC, whichever is earlier.**

- **Passed subject to major corrections:** the final thesis and the iThenticate report must be submitted **within 12 months** from the date of the thesis examination, **or a date specified by the TEC, whichever is earlier.**

Failure to meet the above mentioned submission deadlines: If a candidate fails to submit the final thesis before his/her specific deadline, the candidate will be deemed to have failed to meet the thesis examination requirements of the University and to have failed the requirements of the degree program being pursued. If the candidate fails to meet the deadline in submitting the final thesis, and the delay is no fault of the candidate, the candidate may appeal for an exception to the above rules in a written letter. The appeal must be supported by the thesis supervisors and PG Coordinator of the Thrust, and endorsed by the relevant Hub. It should then be submitted to FYTGS(GZ) for further arrangements.

However, if students wish to meet a specific degree conferral date, they must submit the final thesis to the University's Thesis Submission System by the deadline required for that degree conferral date.

- After submitting the final thesis to the University's Thesis Submission System, students remind Prime Supervisor to endorse the final thesis via the system within 1-2 days.
- The library conducts validation. Students should ensure that they receive an email from the library confirming that their submission has passed validation. This confirmation indicates that their final thesis submission is complete.
- ARS conducts final graduation check and records the grade of Thesis Research course (6990).

Step 7: Graduation Processing (Administrative Procedure)

- Students clear all outstanding dues, including but not limited to:
 - Finish all financial obligations;

- Return university property/ID (equipment, consumable);
- Clean up RBMS seats;
- Complete university surveys (GS, HSE, CFT etc).
- Students may apply for the **Provision Award Certificate Letter (PACL)** for job seeking or PhD application via ARS E-doc System (<https://acad-edoc.hkust-gz.edu.cn/index>) before CPS approval, normally **after the final thesis passes library validation, ARS completes the final graduation check, and the grade for Thesis Research 6990 has been recorded.**
- The Senate Committee of Postgraduate Studies (CPS) approves students' graduation and ARS will issue an Award Certificate Letter (ACL) to students after CPS's approval. Students can apply for final official transcripts via ARS E-doc System (<https://acad-edoc.hkust-gz.edu.cn/index>) after CPS approval.

Step 8: Degree Conferral

- Normally, the e-copy of the diploma will be issued to graduates a few days after each degree conferral date, while the hard copy will be sent later.

6. Delaying Graduation and Continuing Student Status

According to the handbook, research postgraduate students who are studying beyond the normative period of study (2 years), have met the program course requirements (except for 6990 Thesis Research course) and are in the final stage of thesis writing may apply for “Continuing Student” status and pay a reduced tuition fee equivalent to a quarter of the full-time tuition fee.

➤ Application Procedures

Step 1: Fill in part I and II of the application form “Application for “Continuing Student” Status of Research Postgraduate Students”. (the form can be downloaded through the link below:

[https://document.hkust-gz.edu.cn/office/viewer?key=226&fileType=pdf&fileName=HKUST\(GZ\)+Continuing+Student+Status_Form](https://document.hkust-gz.edu.cn/office/viewer?key=226&fileType=pdf&fileName=HKUST(GZ)+Continuing+Student+Status_Form))

Step 2: Ask Project Supervisor to sign in Part III and Prime Supervisor to sign in Part IV.

Step 3: Send the form to RBM, and RBM will assist in the subsequent procedures of obtaining the signatures of RBM Head and Thrust Head before sending it to ARS for further processing.

Step 4: ARS informs students of the result.

➤ Important Notes

1. **The “Continuing Student” status must be applied for by students and will only become effective upon approval.** Otherwise, they will be registered as a full-time student and required to pay the full-time tuition fee each term.
2. The application must reach the ARS at least four weeks before the start of the term in which the “Continuing Student” status is to be effective. **Therefore, once students meet the criteria and would like to register as a “Continuing Student”, they should ensure that they complete Steps 1 and 2 and send the application form to RBM at least six weeks before the start of the term in which they wish to be registered as a “Continuing Student”.** Late submissions are unlikely to complete the necessary approval process, and they will need to register as a full-time student, paying the full-time tuition fee.
3. “Continuing Students”, regardless of their mode of study, are not eligible to receive any forms of financial assistance, including but not limited to Postgraduate Studentship and Postgraduate Research Assistantship, regardless of the source of funding, and are not entitled to University student accommodation.

4. Once having registered for the “Continuing Student” status, students are NOT allowed to change back to regular student status.
5. There is no time limit for research postgraduates to register as “Continuing Students”. However, the maximum time allowed for degree completion (five years for a master’s degree) still holds.

For detailed information regarding the “Continuing Student Status”, please refer to the [Handbook](#): Registration in Programs-- Continuing Student Status.